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Basic Christianity

by John Stott

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CHAPTER 1

The Right Approach

And, whatever else may be said about him, he was also very much a human being. He was born, he grew, he worked and sweated, rested and slept, he ate and drank, suffered and died like other people. He had a real human body and real human emotions. But can we really believe that he was also in some sense ‘God’? Isn’t the deity of Jesus a rather picturesque Christian superstition?

Is there any evidence for this amazing Christian assertion that the carpenter of Nazareth was the unique Son of God? This question is fundamental. We cannot dodge round it. We must be honest. If Jesus was not God in human flesh, then Christianity is thoroughly discredited. We are left with just another religion with some beautiful ideas and noble ethics; its unique distinctiveness is gone. But there is evidence for the deity of Jesus – good, strong, historical, cumulative evidence; evidence to which an honest person can subscribe without committing intellectual suicide.

There are the extravagant claims which Jesus made for himself, so bold and yet so unassuming. Then there is his unique character. His strength and gentleness, his uncompromising righteousness and tender compassion, his care for children and his love for those at the margins, his self-mastery and self-sacrifice have won the admiration of the world. What is more, his cruel death was not the end of him. It is claimed that he rose again from death, and the circumstantial

evidence for his resurrection is most compelling.

But suppose Jesus was the Son of God – is basic Christianity merely an acceptance of this fact? No. Once persuaded of who he is, we must examine what he came to do. What did he intend to achieve? The Bible's answer is that he 'came into the world to save sinners'. Jesus of Nazareth is the heaven-sent Rescuer whom we all need. We need to be forgiven and brought into friendship with the all-holy God, from whom our sins have separated us.

We need to be set free from our selfishness and given strength to live up to our ideals. We need to learn to love others, friend and enemy alike. This is the meaning of what we call 'salvation'. This is what Christ came to win for us by his death and resurrection. So is basic Christianity the belief that Jesus is the Son of God who came to be the Saviour of the world?

No, it is not even that. To accept that he is divine, to acknowledge our need of salvation, and to believe in the effectiveness of what he did for us are still not enough. Christianity is not just about what we believe; it's also about how we behave. Our intellectual belief may be beyond criticism; but we have to put our beliefs into practice. What then must we do? We must commit ourselves, heart and mind, soul and will, home and life, personally and unreservedly to Jesus Christ.

We must humble ourselves before him. We must trust in him as our Saviour and submit to him as our Lord; and then go on to take our place as loyal members of the church and responsible citizens in

the community. This is basic Christianity, the theme of this book. But before we start by looking at the evidence for Jesus Christ being divine, we need to pause in order to reflect on the right approach to take.

The Christian claim is that we can find God in Jesus Christ. Examining this claim will be much more straightforward when we realize, firstly, that God is himself seeking us and, secondly, that we must ourselves seek God. Chapter 1 THE RIGHT APPROACH ‘In the beginning God.’ The first four words of the Bible are more than a way of launching the story of creation or introducing the book of Genesis.

They supply the key which opens our understanding to the Bible as a whole. They tell us that the religion of the Bible is a religion in which God takes the initiative. The point is that we can never take God by surprise. We can never anticipate him. He always makes the first move. He is always there ‘in the beginning’. Before we existed, God took action. Before we decided to look for God, God had already been looking for us.

The Bible isn’t about people trying to discover God, but about God reaching out to find us. Many people imagine God sitting comfortably on a distant throne, remote, aloof, uninterested, a God who doesn’t really care for our needs and has to be badgered into taking action on our behalf. Such a view is completely wrong. The Bible reveals a God who, long before it even occurs to men and women to turn to him, while they are still lost in darkness and sunk

in sin, takes the initiative, rises from his throne, lays aside his glory, and stoops to seek until he finds them.

This sovereign, forward-looking activity of God is seen in many ways. He has taken the initiative in creation, bringing the universe and everything in it into existence: ‘In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.’ He has taken the initiative in what we call revelation, making known both his nature and his will to humanity: ‘In the past God spoke to our forefathers through the prophets at many times and in various ways, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son...’

He has taken the initiative in the rescue operation of salvation, coming in Jesus Christ to set men and women free from their sins: ‘God...has come and has redeemed his people.’¹ God has created. God has spoken. God has acted. These statements of God’s initiative in three different areas form a summary of the religion of the Bible. It is with the second and third that we shall be concerned in this book, because basic Christianity by definition begins with the historical figure of Jesus Christ.

If God has spoken, his last and greatest word to the world is Jesus Christ. If God has acted, his noblest act is the redemption of the world through Jesus Christ. God has spoken and acted in Jesus Christ. He has said something. He has done something. This means that Christianity is not just pious talk. It is neither a collection of religious ideas nor a catalogue of rules. It is a ‘gospel’ (i.e.

good news) – in the apostle Paul’s words ‘the gospel of God...regarding his Son...Jesus Christ our Lord’.² It is not primarily an invitation for us to do anything; it is supremely a declaration of what God has done in Christ for human beings like ourselves. God has spoken Human beings are insatiably inquisitive creatures. Our minds cannot rest. We are always prying into the unknown. We pursue knowledge with restless energy.

Our lives are a voyage of discovery. We are always asking questions, exploring, investigating, researching. We never grow out of the child’s constant cry of ‘Why?’ When our minds begin to think about God, however, they are bewildered. We grope around in the dark. We flounder helplessly out of our depth. But this should come as no surprise. For surely God, whatever or whoever he may be, is infinite, while we are finite creatures.

He is altogether beyond our understanding. Therefore our minds, wonderfully effective instruments though they are when it comes to scientific investigation, cannot immediately help us here. They cannot reach up into the infinite mind of God. There is no ladder to climb, only a vast, unmeasured gulf. Job, a character in the Bible, is challenged with the question, ‘Can you find out the deep things of God?’ The only answer is ‘No’.

It is impossible. And that is how it would have stayed, had God not taken the initiative to help us. We would have remained forever agnostic, asking – just like Pontius Pilate at the trial of Jesus – ‘What is truth?’ but never staying for an answer, never daring to hope that

we would receive one. We would be those who worship, for it is part of human nature to worship someone or something, but all our altars would be like the one the apostle Paul found in Athens, dedicated ‘To an unknown god’.

But God has spoken. He has taken the initiative to make himself known. The Christian concept of revelation is essentially reasonable. The idea is that God has ‘unveiled’ to our minds what would otherwise have been hidden from them. Part of his revelation is in nature: The heavens declare the glory of God; ...the skies proclaim the work of his hands. What may be known about God is plain to them [that is, human beings], because God has made it plain to them.

For since the creation of the world God’s invisible qualities – his eternal power and divine nature – have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made.³ We call this God’s ‘general’ revelation (because it is made to all people everywhere) or ‘natural’ revelation (because it is in nature). But it is not sufficient. Yes, it reveals his existence, and gives us hints of his divine power, glory and faithfulness.

But if we are to come to know God personally, to have our sins forgiven and to enter into relationship with him, we need something which goes further. We need something which helps us find out how to get to know him for ourselves. God’s disclosure of himself needs to include his holiness, his love and his power to save from sin. The wonderful truth is that God gives us this as well.

We call this a ‘special’ revelation, because it was made to a special people (the nation of Israel) through special messengers (people who are identified as ‘prophets’ in the Old Testament and ‘apostles’ in the New). It is also ‘supernatural’, because it was given through a process we call ‘inspiration’, and it found its chief expression in Jesus – in who he is and in what he has done. The way in which the Bible explains and describes this revelation is simply to say that God has ‘spoken’.

Speech is what we ourselves use where we can in order to communicate with one another most straightforwardly. It is by our words that we let others know what is in our minds. This is even more true of God in his desire to reveal his infinite mind to our finite minds. Since, as the prophet Isaiah put it, his thoughts are higher than our thoughts – as much as the heavens are higher than the earth – we could never get to know those thoughts unless he clothed them in words.

The way the Bible puts it is that ‘the word of the Lord came’ to many prophets, until at last Jesus Christ came, and ‘the Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us’.⁴ Paul wrote to his Christian friends in the city of Corinth along similar lines: ‘...since in the wisdom of God the world through its wisdom did not know him, God was pleased through the foolishness of what was preached to save those who believe.’

We come to know God, not through our own wisdom, but through God’s word (identified by Paul here as ‘what we preach’);

not through our human reason, but through divine revelation. It is because God has made himself known in Christ that the Christian can boldly go to those who are agnostic or superstitious and say to them, just as Paul did to the Athenians on the Areopagus, ‘What you worship as something unknown I am going to proclaim to you.’

Much of the controversy between science and religion has arisen through a failure to appreciate this point. Scientific methods are no use when it comes to religion. Scientific knowledge advances through observation and experiment. It works on data supplied to us by our five physical senses. But when we enquire into what lies beyond the observable universe, when we seek to reflect on the metaphysical, there is no data for us to make use of.

We cannot touch, see or hear God directly. Yet the Christian faith is based on the assertion that there once was a time when he chose to speak, and to clothe himself with a body which could be seen and touched. So in the New Testament, John began his first letter with the claim, ‘That which was from the beginning, which we have heard, which we have seen with our eyes, which we have looked at and our hands have touched...we proclaim to you...’

God has taken action The Christian good news is not simply a declaration that God has said something. It also affirms that God has done something. God has taken the initiative in both these ways because this is what we need. It isn’t just that we are ignorant but also that we are sinful. This is why it isn’t enough for God simply to reveal himself to us and dispel our ignorance.

He must also take action to save us from our sins. He began in Old Testament days. He called Abraham from his home in Ur, making him and his descendants into a nation, rescuing them from slavery in Egypt, entering into a covenant with them at Mount Sinai, leading them across the desert into the Promised Land, guiding and teaching them as his special people. All this was by way of preparation for his even greater deed of redemption in Christ.

People needed to be delivered, not from slavery in Egypt or from exile in Babylon, but from the bondage and alienation of sin. It was chiefly for this that Jesus Christ came. He came as a Saviour. ...You are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins. Here is a trustworthy saying that deserves full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners.

For the Son of Man came to seek and to save what was lost. He was like the shepherd in the parable told by Jesus who missed the only sheep which was lost from the flock and went out to search until he found it.⁵ Christianity is a religion of salvation, and the fact is that there is nothing in any of the non-Christian religions to compare with this message of a God who loved, and came after, and died for, a world of lost sinners.

Our response God has spoken. God has taken action. The record and interpretation of these divine words and deeds is to be found in the Bible. The problem for many people is that this is where they remain. It's all too easy to imagine that what God has said and done is all in the past and just leave it at that. But it needs to come out of

history into experience, out of the Bible into life.

God has spoken – but have we listened to his word? God has acted – but have we benefited from what he has done? God has spoken – but have we listened to his word? God has acted – but have we benefited from what he has done? What we must do will be explained in the rest of this book. At this stage it is necessary to make just one point: we must seek.

God has sought us. He is still seeking us. We must seek him. Indeed, God's chief quarrel with us is that we do not seek. The LORD looks down from heaven on the human race to see if there are any who understand, any who seek God. All have turned away, all have become corrupt; there is no-one who does good, not even one.⁶ Yet Jesus promised: 'Seek and you will find.'

If we do not seek, we shall never find. Jesus told three stories to illustrate this point. The shepherd searched until he found the lost sheep. The woman hunted until she found her lost coin. The father was constantly on the lookout for his lost son. Why should we expect to do less? God desires to be found, but only by those who seek him. We must seek seriously. 'Man is as lazy as he dares to be,' as the American writer Emerson put it.

But what we're dealing with is so important that we must overcome our natural laziness and apathy and give our minds to the search. God has little patience with those who just trifle with him; 'he rewards those who earnestly seek him'.⁷ We must seek humbly. If apathy is a hindrance to some people, pride is an even greater and

more common hindrance to others. We must freely admit that our minds, being finite, cannot possibly discover God by their own efforts.

We depend on God to make himself known. I am not saying that we should suspend rational thinking. On the contrary, the psalmist encourages us not to be ‘like the horse or the mule which have no understanding’. We must use our minds; but we must also admit their limitations. Jesus said, ‘I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because you have hidden these things from the wise and learned, and revealed them to little children.’

It is one of the reasons why Jesus loved children. They are teachable. They are not proud, self-important and critical. We need the open, humble and receptive mind of a little child. We must seek honestly. We must come to what claims to be God’s revelation of himself not only without pride, but without prejudice; not only with a humble mind, but with an open mind. All students know the dangers of approaching their subject with preconceived ideas.

Yet many would-be enquirers come to the Bible with their minds already made up. We need to remember that God’s promise is addressed only to the earnest seeker: ‘You will seek me and find me when you seek me with all your heart.’⁸ So we must lay aside our prejudice and open our minds to the possibility that Christianity may after all be true. We must seek obediently. This is the hardest condition of all to fulfil.

In seeking God we have to be prepared not only to revise our ideas, but to reform our lives. The Christian message has a moral challenge. If the message is true, this moral challenge has to be accepted. The point is that we cannot treat God as if he were an object for our detached scrutiny. We cannot fix him at the end of a telescope or a microscope and say, 'How interesting!'

God is far from being merely interesting. He is deeply upsetting. The same is true of Jesus Christ. We had thought intellectually to examine him; we find he is spiritually examining us. The roles are reversed between us...A person may study Jesus with intellectual impartiality, he cannot do it with moral neutrality...We must declare our colours.⁹ This is what Jesus was getting at when, talking to some people in his own day who refused to accept him, he said, 'If anyone chooses to do God's will, he will find out whether my teaching comes from God or whether I speak on my own.'

The promise is clear: we can certainly know whether Jesus Christ was true or false, whether his teaching was human or divine. But the promise has a moral condition attached to it. We have to be ready not just to believe, but to obey. We must be prepared to do God's will when he makes it known. I remember a young man coming to see me when he had just left school and begun work in London.

He had given up going to church, he said, because he could not say the creed without feeling that he was a hypocrite. He no longer believed it. When he had finished telling me what he thought, I said to him, 'If I were to answer your problems to your complete

intellectual satisfaction, would you be willing to change the way you live?’ He smiled slightly and blushed. The answer was clearly ‘No’.

His real problem was not intellectual but moral. This, then, is the spirit in which our search must be conducted. We must set aside apathy, pride, prejudice and sin, and seek God – no matter what the consequences. Of all these hindrances to the search for truth, the last two are the hardest to overcome: intellectual prejudice and moral selfwill. The reason is that both are expressions of fear – and fear is the greatest enemy of the truth.

Fear paralyses our search. It isn’t long before we realize that to find God and to accept Jesus Christ is a very inconvenient experience for most people. It would involve us rethinking our whole outlook on life and lead to major changes in the way we live. Such a combination of intellectual and moral cowardice makes us hesitate. We do not find because we do not seek. And the truth is that we do not seek because we do not really want to find.

And the best way to be certain that we won’t find is to decide against looking in the first place. So let me urge you to be open to the possibility that you may not have got this right and that Christ may in fact be true. And if you want to be a humble, honest, obedient seeker after God, spend some time reading the Bible, the book which claims to be his revelation.

Look particularly at the Gospels, which tell the story of Jesus Christ. Give him the opportunity to confront you with himself and to authenticate himself to you. Come with the full consent of your mind

and will, ready to believe and obey if you become convinced that it's true. Why not read through the Gospel of Mark, or John? You could read either through in one go (preferably in a modern translation), to let it make its total impact on you.

Then you could reread it slowly, say a chapter a day. Before you read, pray – perhaps something along these lines: God, if you exist (and I don't know you do), and you can hear this prayer (and I don't know if you can), I want to tell you that I am an honest seeker after the truth. Show me if Jesus is your Son and the Saviour of the world.

And if you bring conviction to my mind, I will trust him as my Saviour and follow him as my Lord. No-one can pray such a prayer and be disappointed. God keeps his promises. He honours all earnest searching. He rewards all honest seekers. The undertaking given by Jesus is very clear: 'Seek and you will find.' Study Questions 1. In what ways are the first four words of the Bible 'the key which opens our understanding to the Bible as a whole'?

2. How would you go about putting together 'a summary of the religion of the Bible'? 3. What differences are there between God's 'general' or 'natural' revelation and his 'special' revelation? Why are these distinctions so important? 4. '...it isn't enough for God simply to reveal himself to us in order to dispel our ignorance.' Why not? What more does he need to do? 5. What did Jesus come to do?

In what ways does this make Christianity unique? 6. Why is it so important for us to 'seek' God? What does this mean in practice? How do we do it? Chapter 2 THE CLAIMS OF CHRIST We have

seen that we need to seek in order to find. But where are we to begin our search? The Christian answer is that we need to start with Jesus of Nazareth. The distinctively Christian claim about God is that he has spoken and acted fully and finally in Jesus Christ.

So the crucial question is this: was this Jesus, the carpenter of Nazareth, the Son of God or not? There are two main reasons why our investigation into Christianity should begin with the person of Christ. The first is that, in essence, Christianity is Christ. Who Christ is and what he has done are the rock upon which the Christian religion is built. If he was not who he said he was, and if he did not do what he said he had come to do, then the foundation is undermined and the whole thing will collapse.

Take Christ from Christianity, and you remove the heart from it; there is practically nothing left. Christ is the centre of Christianity; everything else is peripheral. We are not concerned primarily with the effect he has had on the world, important though that is. Our concern is basically with the man himself. Who was he? Take Christ from Christianity, and you remove the heart from it; there is practically nothing left.

Christ is the centre of Christianity; everything else is peripheral. Secondly, once we accept that Jesus Christ is a uniquely divine person, many of the knots we get into with religion begin to untangle. For one thing, the divinity of Jesus helps us sort out questions about who God really is and what he is like. But it doesn't stop there. For if it's true that Jesus is divine, then it follows that

what he taught must be true.

And that sheds light on all sorts of important issues to do with Christian faith – such as (as we shall see) the purpose of life, what happens after death, the place of the Old Testament and the significance of the death of Jesus on the cross. Our investigation must therefore begin with Jesus Christ, and to study him properly we must turn to the Gospels in the New Testament.

We don't need at this point to go along with the Christian view and accept them as the inspired Word of God. All we need to do is take them seriously as the undeniably historical documents that they are. This isn't the place to consider detailed questions about their literary origin.¹ It is sufficient just to emphasize that their authors were all Christians, that there's no reason to believe that Christians are any less honest than anyone else, and that what they say at least appears to be objective and to include the recollections of eyewitnesses.

So for the time being, let me invite you to think of them simply as a substantially accurate record of the life and teaching of Jesus. In doing so, we're not going to rely on a few obscure and isolated proof texts. Instead we shall concentrate on what is clear and straightforward. Our purpose is to bring together the main evidence which demonstrates that Jesus was the Son of God.

It won't be enough to reach the conclusion that he simply exhibited a few divine characteristics. The truth to establish is his undeniable deity. Christians believe that Jesus has an eternal and

essential relation to God that no-one else has or has ever had. We don't think of him as God in human disguise or as someone who simply displayed divine qualities to an impressive degree, but as the God-man.

We are persuaded that Jesus was a historical person who possessed two distinct and perfect natures, one divine and one human, and that this makes him absolutely and for ever unique. In short, we believe him to be worthy not just of our admiration, but also of our worship. The evidence is at least threefold. It concerns the claims he made, the character he displayed and his resurrection from the dead.

No single argument is conclusive by itself. But these three strands weave together and point clearly to the same conclusion. The first witness, then, is what Christ said about himself. In the words of Archbishop William Temple, 'It is now recognized that the one Christ for whose existence there is any evidence at all is a miraculous Figure making stupendous claims.' It is of course true that claims do not in themselves constitute evidence.

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The Claims of Christ

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And that sheds light on all sorts of important issues to do with Christian faith – such as (as we shall see) the purpose of life, what happens after death, the place of the Old Testament and the significance of the death of Jesus on the cross. Our investigation must therefore begin with Jesus Christ, and to study him properly we must turn to the Gospels in the New Testament.

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But the claims that Jesus made are remarkable and demand some sort of an explanation. For the sake of clarity, we shall need to distinguish between four different kinds of claim. His self-centred teaching The most striking feature of the teaching of Jesus is that he was constantly talking about himself. It is true that he said a great deal about the fatherhood of God and the kingdom of God.

But then he added that he is the Father's 'Son', and that he himself had come to launch the kingdom. Entry into the kingdom depends on how people respond to him personally. He even went so far as to call the kingdom of God 'my kingdom'. This self-centredness of the teaching of Jesus immediately sets him apart from the other great religious teachers of the world. They tend to be self-effacing.

He is self-advancing. They point people away from themselves, saying, 'That is the truth, so far as I understand it; follow that.' Jesus says, 'I am the truth; follow me.' No other religious founder who dared to say such a thing would be taken seriously. The personal pronoun forces itself repeatedly on our attention as we read his words. For example: I am the bread of life. Whoever comes to me will never go hungry, and whoever believes in me will never be thirsty.

I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will never walk in darkness, but will have the light of life. I am the resurrection and the life. Anyone who believes in me will live, even though they die; and whoever lives by believing in me will never die. I am the way

and the truth and the life. No-one comes to the Father except through me. Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.

Take my yoke upon you and learn from me...² The great question to which the first phase of his teaching leads is, ‘Who do you say that I am?’ He refers back to figures from the distant past and makes the astonishing claim that Abraham rejoiced to see his day, that Moses wrote about him, that the Scriptures point to him, and that indeed in the three great divisions of the Old Testament – the Law, the Prophets and the Writings – there are things ‘concerning himself’.³ Luke describes in some detail the dramatic visit which Jesus pays to the synagogue of his home village, Nazareth.

He was given a scroll of the Old Testament Scriptures and he stood up to read. The passage is from the book of the prophet Isaiah 61:1–2: The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to proclaim good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to set the oppressed free, to proclaim the year of the Lord’s favour.⁴ He closed the book, returned it to the synagogue attendant and sat down, while the eyes of all the congregation were fastened on him.

He then broke the silence with the amazing words, ‘Today this scripture is fulfilled in your hearing.’ In other words, ‘Isaiah was writing about me.’ With such an opinion of himself, it comes as no surprise that he called people to himself. Indeed, he did more than offer a polite invitation; he issued a firm command. ‘Come to me,’

he said. ‘Follow me.’ If people would only come to him, he promised to lift the burdens of the weary, to satisfy the hungry, and to quench the longing of the thirsty soul.⁵ More than that, his followers were to obey him and to make no secret of their allegiance to him.

His disciples came to recognize the right of Jesus to make these wholesale claims, and in their letters Paul, Peter, James and Jude delight to describe themselves as his ‘slaves’. Furthermore, he offered himself to his contemporaries as someone in whom they should put their faith and to whom they should offer their love. People are supposed to believe in God – yet Jesus urged people to believe in himself.

‘The work of God is this: to believe in the one he has sent.’ ‘Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life.’ If to believe in him is our first duty, not to believe in him is our chief sin.⁶ Again, the first and greatest commandment is for us to love God with all that we are – heart and soul and mind. Yet Jesus audaciously claimed the supreme place for himself.

Anyone who loves father, mother, son or daughter more than him is not worthy of him, he said. Indeed, resorting to the vivid Hebrew use of contrast to convey comparison, he added: ‘If anyone comes to me and does not hate father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters – yes, even life itself – such a person cannot be my disciple.’⁷ So convinced was he of his central place in the purpose of God that he promised to send someone to take his place after he

returned to heaven.

This is the Holy Spirit. Christ's favourite name for him is translated in John's Gospel as the Advocate, the 'One who comes alongside to help'. It is a legal term, denoting a barrister, a counsel for the defence. It would be the Holy Spirit's task to carry forward the cause of Jesus. 'He will testify about me,' said Jesus. Again, 'He will glorify me because it is from me that he will receive what he will make known to you.'⁸ So the Holy Spirit's role, both within the Christian community and in the wider world, would be to focus on Jesus Christ.

In one more flash of breathtaking egocentricity, Jesus predicted: 'I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to myself.' He knew that the cross would be like a moral magnet which people would find most intriguing. But his understanding was that this attraction would bring them, first and foremost, not to God or the church, not to truth or to righteousness, but to himself. Indeed, it's only by being brought to him that people would come to embrace these other realities as well.

But the most remarkable feature of all this self-centred teaching is that it stemmed from one who insisted on humility in others. He rebuked his disciples for their self-seeking attitudes and was wearied by their desire to be great. But hold on a moment! Did he not practise what he preached? After all, he placed a little child before them and said that he was to be their model. Did he have a different standard for himself?

His direct claims Jesus clearly believed himself to be the Messiah predicted by the Old Testament. He came to establish what he called ‘the kingdom of God’, the coming of which had been foretold by generations of prophets. It is significant that his first recorded words in the public arena were about the fulfilment of these ancient promises: ‘The time has come; the kingdom of God has come near.’ He assumed the title ‘Son of Man’, which is an accepted messianic title derived originally from one of the prophet Daniel’s visions.

He accepted the description ‘Son of God’ when challenged by the high priest at his trial, which is another messianic title taken particularly from Psalm 2:7. He also interpreted his mission in the light of the portrayal of the suffering servant of the Lord in the latter part of the book of Isaiah. The first stage in his instruction of the core group of his disciples led up to an incident at Caesarea Philippi when Simon Peter declared his faith in Jesus as the Christ.

Others might think of him as one of the prophets; but Simon has come to recognize him as the One to whom the prophets pointed. He is not just another signpost, but the destination to which the signposts have led.⁹ The whole account of what Jesus said and did is shaped by this sense of fulfilment. ‘Blessed are the eyes that see what you see,’ he once said privately to his disciples.

‘For I tell you that many prophets and kings wanted to see what you see but did not see it, and to hear what you hear but did not hear it.’¹⁰ But the direct claims which concern us here refer not just to his being the Messiah, but to his deity. His claim to be the Son of

God is more than messianic; it describes his unique and eternal relationship with God.

Let's explore three examples of this greater claim. First, there is the way he constantly referred to the close association he had with God as his 'Father'. Even as a boy of twelve he astonished his human parents with an uncompromising enthusiasm for his heavenly Father's business. And then he went on to say things like this: My Father is always at his work to this very day, and I, too, am working.

I and the Father are one. I am in the Father and the Father is in me.¹¹ It is true that he taught his disciples to address God as 'Father' as well, but the way in which he is the Son of God is so different from the way in which anyone else is a child of God that he has to distinguish between them. To him God is uniquely 'my Father'.

This is why, when talking with Mary Magdalene after his resurrection, he said, 'I am ascending to my Father and your Father.' It just wouldn't have been appropriate for him to say, 'I ascend to our Father.' These verses are all taken from John's Gospel, but the same unique relationship with God is claimed by Jesus in Matthew 11:27 where he says, 'All things have been committed to me by my Father.

No-one knows the Son except the Father, and no-one knows the Father except the Son and those to whom the Son chooses to reveal him.' That Jesus did in fact claim this very close relationship with God is further confirmed by the indignation which he aroused in the

religious leaders who opposed him. He ‘claimed to be the Son of God’, they said.¹² His identification with God was so close that it was natural for him to equate the attitude people had to him with the attitude they had to God.

In short: to know him is to know God; to see him is to see God; to believe in him is to believe in God; to receive him is to receive God; to hate him is to hate God; to honour him is to honour God.¹³ These are some of the general claims which Jesus made about his unique relationship to God. He also made two more direct claims. The first is recorded at the end of the eighth chapter of John’s Gospel.

In an argument with some of the Jewish leaders he said: ‘Very truly I tell you, whoever obeys my word will never see death’ (TNIV). This was too much for his critics. ‘Abraham died’, they expostulated, ‘and so did the prophets...Are you greater than our father Abraham?...Who do you think you are?’ ‘Your father Abraham rejoiced at the thought of seeing my day,’ Jesus replied. They were yet more puzzled.

‘You are not yet fifty years old...and you have seen Abraham!’ And Jesus responded with one of the most far-reaching claims he ever made: ‘Very truly I tell you...before Abraham was born, I am!’ (TNIV) Then they picked up stones to throw at him. According to the law of Moses, stoning was the penalty for blasphemy. At first sight, we might wonder what they saw as blasphemous in what Jesus said.

Of course there is the claim to have lived before Abraham. This was a claim he often made. He had ‘come down’ from heaven and ‘been sent’ by the Father, for example. But this claim was innocent enough. We must look further. The clue comes from the fact that he didn’t say ‘Before Abraham was, I was’, but ‘Before Abraham was, I am’. Jesus was claiming that he had existed eternally before Abraham.

But even that is not all. For ‘I am’ implies a claim not only to eternity, but also to deity. ‘I am’ is the divine Name by which God had revealed himself to Moses, when he was travelling through the desert and encountered God at the burning bush. ‘I AM WHO I AM. This is what you are to say to the Israelites: “I AM has sent me to you.”

’ It is this divine title that Jesus quietly used of himself. This is what led the religious leaders to pick up stones in order to punish what they saw as the blasphemy of Jesus. The second example of a direct claim to deity took place after the resurrection (assuming for the moment that the resurrection took place). John reports (20:26–29) that on the Sunday following Easter Day, doubting Thomas (who had missed the appearance of Jesus a week earlier) was with the other disciples in the upper room when Jesus appeared.

He invited Thomas to touch his wounds, and Thomas, overwhelmed with wonder, cried out, ‘My Lord and my God!’ Jesus calmly accepted this description of himself. He rebuked Thomas, yes – but for his unbelief, not for his worship. His indirect claims It isn’t

only the things which Jesus said directly that support his claim to deity. There are also the indirect ways in which he made it clear that this is how he saw himself.

The implications of what he was doing were as eloquent an indication of who he is as were his plain statements. On many occasions he did things which only God should do. We'll look at four of them. The first is the claim to forgive sins. On two separate occasions,¹⁴ Jesus is recorded as forgiving sinners. The first time, the friends of a paralysed man brought him to Jesus by letting him down through the roof on the mat he was using as a bed.

Jesus recognized that his need was basically spiritual and surprised the crowd by saying to him, 'Son, your sins are forgiven,' before going on to heal his physical problem as well. The second declaration of forgiveness was made to a woman known to be living an immoral life, who came to see Jesus while he was having a meal at the home of a religious leader. She came up behind him while he was reclining at the table and washed his feet with her tears.

Then she wiped them with her hair, kissed them and poured perfume on them. And Jesus said to her, 'Your sins are forgiven.' On both occasions the onlookers raise their eyebrows and ask, 'Who is this? What blasphemy is this? Who but God can forgive sins?' They're quite right to be concerned. We may forgive the injuries which others do to us; but the sins we commit against God can surely only be forgiven by God himself.

Christ's second indirect claim is to give life. He described himself as 'the bread of life', 'the life' and 'the resurrection and the life'. He likened his followers' dependence on him to the sustenance derived from the vine by its branches. He offered a woman from Samaria 'living water' and promised eternal life to a rich young man if he will come and follow him. He called himself the Good Shepherd who will not only give his life for the sheep, but give life to them.

He stated that God has granted him authority over all people that he might give life to as many as God gives him, and declared, 'The Son gives life to whom he is pleased to give it.'¹⁵ So definite is this claim that his disciples clearly recognized the truth of it. It made leaving him impossible. 'To whom shall we go?' asked Peter. 'You have the words of eternal life.'

Life is an enigma. Whether we're talking about physical life or spiritual life, its nature is as baffling as its origin. We can neither define what it is, nor state where it comes from. We can only call it a gift from God. It is this gift which Jesus claims to give. Christ's third indirect claim is to teach the truth. It is not so much the truths which he taught as the direct and dogmatic manner in which he taught them which attracts our attention.

His contemporaries were deeply impressed by his wisdom. Where did this man get these things?...What's this wisdom that has been given to him?...Isn't this the carpenter? How did this man get such learning without having been taught? But they were even more

impressed by his authority. No-one ever spoke the way this man does. His words had authority. When Jesus had finished saying these things, the crowds were amazed at his teaching, because he taught as one who had authority, and not as their teachers of the law.¹⁶ His authority was unlike that of the experts in religious law, who never taught without quoting from the authorities which backed them up.

Neither was it like the authority of the prophets. They spoke with the authority of God, but Jesus claimed an authority all of his own. His formula was not ‘This is what God says’, but ‘This is what I say’. It is true that he said that his ideas were not his own, but came from the Father who sent him. Even so, he knew himself to be such a clear source of divine revelation that he was able to speak with enormous personal confidence.

He never hesitated or apologized. He had no need to contradict, withdraw or modify anything he said. He spoke the unequivocal words of God: ‘He whom God has sent utters the words of God.’ He predicted the future with complete conviction. He issued absolute moral commands like ‘Love your enemies’, ‘Do not worry about your life’, ‘Do not judge, or you too will be judged’. He made promises with no doubt that they would be honoured: ‘Ask and it will be given to you.’

He asserted that, even though heaven and earth pass away, his words will never go the same way. He warned those who heard him that their destiny depended on how they chose to respond to his teaching – just as, in Old Testament times, the destiny of the people

of Israel had depended on their response to God's Word. Christ's fourth indirect claim is to judge the world. This is perhaps the most extraordinary of all his statements.

Several of his parables imply that he personally will come back at the end of the world, and that the final day of reckoning will not take place until then. He will himself wake up the dead, and the whole world will be gathered before him. He will sit on the throne of his glory, and the judgment will be entrusted to him by the Father. He will then separate people from one another as a shepherd separates his sheep from his goats.

Some will be invited to come and inherit the kingdom prepared for them since the creation of the world. Others will hear the dreadful words, 'Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels.'¹⁷ Not only will Jesus be the Judge, but the basis of judgment will be people's attitude to him as shown in their treatment of his 'brothers and sisters' or their response to his word.

He will acknowledge before his Father in heaven those who have publicly acknowledged him; he will disown those who have publicly disowned him. Indeed, to be excluded from heaven on the last day, it will be enough for Jesus to say to them, quite simply, 'I never knew you.'¹⁸ It is hard to exaggerate the enormity of this claim. Imagine a minister addressing his congregation in these terms today: 'Listen carefully to my words.

Your eternal destiny depends on it. I am going to return at the end of the world to judge you, and your fate will be settled according to whether or not you obey me.’ Such a preacher would soon be under psychiatric care! His dramatized claims It remains for us to consider the recorded miracles of Jesus. A helpful way of approaching these is to see them as his dramatized claims.

This is no place for a thorough discussion of whether or not miracles can happen or what they are for. All we need do here is to make the point that the value of Christ’s miracles comes not so much from their supernatural character as from their spiritual significance. They were ‘signs’ as well as ‘wonders’. They were never performed selfishly or senselessly. Their purpose was not to show off or to force people into submission.

They were not so much demonstrations of special power as illustrations of moral authority. They are in fact the acted parables of Jesus. They demonstrate his claims visually. The things he does dramatize the things he says. John understood this very clearly. He constructs his Gospel around six or seven selected ‘signs’ (see 20:30–31), and associates them with the great ‘I am’ declarations which Jesus made in his preaching and teaching.

The first sign was the changing of water into wine at a wedding reception in Cana of Galilee. The event itself doesn’t really tell us very much. Its significance lies more beneath the surface. John tells us that the stone water jars stood ready ‘for ceremonial washing’. What we might pass over as merely an incidental reference turns out

to be the clue we are seeking. The water stood for the old religion.

The wine stood for the religion of Jesus. Just as he changed the water into wine, so his gospel would supersede the law. The sign backed up the claim that Jesus was the one who would bring in this new order. He was the Messiah. As he was soon to say to the Samaritan woman, 'I am he.' Similarly, his feeding of the five thousand illustrated his claim to satisfy the hunger of the human heart.

'I am the bread of life,' he said. A little later, he opened the eyes of a man born blind, having earlier stated, 'I am the light of the world.' If he could restore sight to the blind, he can open people's eyes to see and to know God. Finally, he brought back to life a man called Lazarus who had been dead for four days, and claimed, 'I am the resurrection and the life.'

He had resuscitated a dead man. Again, it was a sign. The life of the body symbolizes the life of the soul. Christ could be the life of the believer before death and will be the resurrection of the believer after death. All these miracles are parables, illustrating the truth that as human beings we are spiritually hungry, blind and dead, and that only Christ can satisfy our hunger, restore our sight and raise us to a new life.¹⁹ Conclusion It just isn't possible to eliminate these claims from the teaching of the carpenter of Nazareth.

We can't say that they were invented by the evangelists, nor even that they were unconsciously exaggerated. They are widely and evenly distributed in the different Gospels and sources of the

Gospels, and the portrait is too consistent and too balanced to have been dreamed up by the writers. The claims are there. It is of course true that they do not in themselves constitute evidence of deity. After all, claims can be false.

But some explanation of them must be found. We simply can't go on treating Jesus as a great teacher if he was completely mistaken in one of the chief subjects of his teaching – himself. As many scholars have recognized, there is a certain disturbing 'megalomania' about Jesus. These claims in a mere man would be egoism carried even to imperial megalomania.²⁰ The discrepancy between the depth and sanity, and (let me add) shrewdness, of his moral teaching and the rampant megalomania which must lie behind his theological teaching unless he is indeed God, has never been satisfactorily got over.²¹ Was he then a deliberate impostor?

Did he attempt to persuade people to accept his views by assuming a divine authority he did not possess? This is very difficult to believe. Jesus comes across as being entirely straightforward in his dealings with people. He hated hypocrisy in others and was transparently sincere himself. Was he then sincerely mistaken? Did he have a fixed delusion about himself? This possibility has its supporters, but leaves one feeling that their delusion is greater than his.

Jesus does not give the impression of the sort of abnormality which one expects to find in those who are deluded. His claims appear to be supported by his character, which is what we shall look

at next. Study Questions 1. Why should an investigation into Christianity begin with the person of Jesus Christ? 2. How would you justify the use of the Gospels as reliable sources of information about Jesus?

3. What are the three main strands of evidence which lead to the conclusion that Jesus is ‘worthy not just of our admiration, but also of our worship’? 4. What is so remarkable about the self-centredness of Jesus’ teaching? 5. In what ways did Jesus claim, both directly and indirectly, to be the Son of God? 6. Why would it be wrong simply to label Jesus as a ‘great teacher’?